objective of finding the right number and status of socially and economically backward categories to better plan welfare measures. The political motive behind these surveys is to mobilise the OBC support base as there has never been a count of OBCs since 1931. Though OBCs have 27 per cent reservation in government jobs and educational institutes, the share of OBC population is assumed to be far higher than the 52 per cent estimated in 1931. An accurate estimate may provide an empirical basis to their demand for a greater share in the reservation pie. Even the report examining the 1996 women's reservation bill recommended that reservation be provided for OBC women once the Constitution was amended to allow for OBC reservation. The standing committee examining the 2008 bill reiterated the same.

The Opposition parties believe that by fuelling OBC concerns, they may yet split the BJP's Hindutva vote under which it seeks to unite all Hindu caste groups under one umbrella. As Congress leader Rahul Gandhi pointed out in Parliament, of the 90 bureaucrats in the Union government, only three are OBC. On its part, the BJP, despite promising a caste census in 2018, has steered clear of initiating any such exercise. The Opposition demand for a specific quota for OBC women is aimed at further cornering the BJP on this issue. Psephologist Gupta, though, is sceptical of this making any difference. "This is unlikely to have any major impact as there has been no reservation for OBCs in Parliament and assemblies till now. Political parties like the SP and RJD, which have based their electoral politics on OBCs, are trying to rake up the issue with a political motive, but it will not negate the gains BJP may get through the women's reservation bill," he says.

DOES RESERVATION HELP?

Most political experts agree that political reservation is crucial for women's empowerment. Female politicians, they argue, are more likely to take up issues that concern their gender, be it of equal rights, safety and security, or women's healthcare, and bring more experientially aware elements to areas such as child care. With a rising graph of gender-based violence, it's crucial that they play a leading role in policy-making against such social menaces. "It is crucial that women find a voice in decision-making and debates with regard to the direction of public policy," says Prof. Indu Agnihotri, former director of CWDS. "While women alone do not represent women, it is imperative they be party to significant deliberations on developmental policies that directly impact their lives."

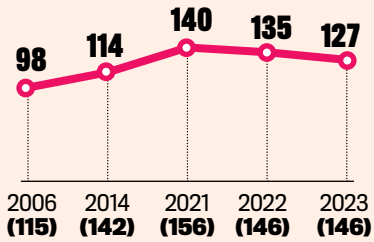
Gender experts also cite empirical evidence to suggest that reservation for women in policy-making is crucial for ideal policy outcomes. A 2004 study by Raghabendra Chattopadhyay and Esther Duflo in Rajasthan and West Bengal found that women's quota in panchayats led to a marked change in local government policies as female leaders took decisions that more closely reflected rural issues. "Once women started getting better representation in panchayats, the first thing that happened was people-friendly decision-making instead of infrastructure-intensive decision-making. The focus was more on education and healthcare than on unnecessary and unviable infrastructure projects," says former CEC Om Prakash Rawat.

THE CHALLENGES

While the women's reservation bill has been universally welcomed, scholars say there is a vast difference in representation and participation in decision-making, going by past experience. A 2009 study by Prof. Nupur Tiwary, chair professor of the Dr Ambedkar Chair in Social Justice at the Indian Institute of Public Administration, found that 94 per cent of the women

THE WIDE INDIAN GENDER GAP

The Global Gender Gap Index was first introduced by the World Economic Forum in 2006 to benchmark progress towards gender parity by countries across the world. While India's performance has been consistently poor, its ranking has shown improvement over the past three years



No. of countries surveyed in ( )

INDIA'S PERFORMANCE ACROSS CATEGORIES

The report compares countries' gender gaps across four dimensions—economic opportunities, education, health and political leadership. India's biggest cause of concern are health and economic indicators where the country has been consistently positioned at the bottom

India's rank in...

